Recovering unsaved or corrupted Office files

Article KB0010060 | Owner: Application Support | Subcategory: Microsoft Office | Applies to: Windows 11 23H2/24H2 (Dell Latitude 5440/7440, Lenovo ThinkPad T14/X1 Carbon, HP EliteBook 840), macOS 14/15 (MacBook Pro/Air), Microsoft 365 Apps for enterprise (Word, Excel, PowerPoint, OneNote)

Summary

This article guides users through recovering unsaved work or repairing corrupted Microsoft Office files (Word, Excel, PowerPoint) on Acme Global managed devices. It outlines self-help steps such as using AutoRecover, opening files in Safe Mode, running Office Quick Repair, and checking add-ins, then describes the service-desk workflow for deeper diagnostics and escalation.

Symptoms

- Excel crashes when opening a specific workbook or shows "Excel stopped working"
- Word displays "Word encountered a problem and needs to close" or refuses to open a document
- PowerPoint prompts "Office needs to be activated" even though a valid license exists
- File opens but shows garbled content, missing formulas, or "The file is corrupted and cannot be opened" message
- Office applications run unusually slow or freeze intermittently

Common causes

- Unexpected shutdown or power loss preventing AutoRecover save
- Corrupted file due to network interruption while saving to OneDrive/SharePoint
- Faulty COM add-in or macro causing application instability
- Outdated Office build or pending Windows updates affecting compatibility
- License token expiration or synchronization issue with Microsoft Entra ID

Self-help troubleshooting

Follow these steps to try to recover unsaved work or repair a corrupted Office file before contacting the Service Desk. Most issues are resolved with built-in recovery features or a quick repair of the Office installation.

1. 1. Check for AutoRecover versions
   - In Word, Excel, or PowerPoint, go to **File -> Info -> Manage Document -> Recover Unsaved Documents** (or **Workbooks**/**Presentations**).
   - If a recovered version appears, open it and immediately **Save As** to a safe location (e.g., your OneDrive folder).
2. Open the file in Safe Mode to bypass add-ins
   - Hold **Ctrl** while launching the Office app, or run `excel.exe /safe` from the Run dialog.
   - If the file opens successfully, disable recent add-ins via **File -> Options -> Add-Ins -> Manage: COM Add-ins -> Go...** and uncheck suspicious items.
3. Use the Open and Repair feature
   - In the Office app, choose **File -> Open**, browse to the file, click the dropdown arrow on the **Open** button, and select **Open and Repair**.
   - Choose **Repair** first; if that fails, try **Extract Data** (for Excel) to salvage values.
4. Run Office Quick Repair
   - Open **Settings -> Apps -> Apps & features**, find **Microsoft 365**, click **Modify**, then choose **Quick Repair** and follow the prompts.
   - Restart the computer when prompted and test the file again.
5. Verify license status
   - Open any Office app, go to **File -> Account**. Under **Product Information**, if it shows "Unlicensed Product" or "Needs Activation", sign out (**File -> Account -> Sign out**) and sign back in with your Acme credentials.
   - If the problem persists, note the error code and contact the Service Desk.

Service-desk agent procedure

When a user reports unrecoverable Office files or persistent crashes after self-help, follow this structured workflow to diagnose and resolve the issue. Document each step in the ticket and communicate expected timelines based on

priority.

1. 1. Gather details
   - Confirm the exact Office app, version (via **File -> Account -> About**), and operating system build.
   - Ask for the specific error message(s) and whether the issue affects one file or multiple files.
   - Determine if the file is stored locally, on OneDrive, SharePoint, or a network share.
2. Verify license and activation
   - Have the user sign out of Office and sign back in via **File -> Account**.
   - Check the Microsoft 365 admin portal for any license assignment issues or conditional access policies blocking token acquisition.
3. Test in Safe Mode with networking disabled
   - Instruct the user to launch the Office app with `/safe` and attempt to open the file.
   - If successful, systematically enable add-ins to isolate the faulty one.
4. Run Office Online Repair
   - If Quick Repair did not resolve the issue, escalate to **Online Repair** (Settings -> Apps -> Microsoft 365 -> Modify -> Online Repair). This may take 10-20?minutes and requires internet connectivity.
5. Examine file integrity
   - For OneDrive/SharePoint files, request the user to check the version history and restore a previous known-good version.
   - For local copies, suggest copying the file to a different location (e.g., desktop) and trying Open and Repair again.
6. Collect logs if needed
   - If the problem persists, ask the user to reproduce the issue while capturing **Microsoft Support Diagnostic Tool (MSDT)** logs or enabling **Windows Event Viewer** logs for Application errors.
   - Attach the logs to the ticket for further analysis by the Application Support team.
7. Determine next steps
   - If the file remains corrupted and no backup exists, advise the user to recreate the file from source data or consult the document owner.
   - If the issue is widespread (multiple users/files), consider a possible add-in conflict or Office update problem and escalate to the Application Support group for broader investigation.

Verification

After completing the repair steps, confirm that the user can open and edit the file without errors and that Office applications remain stable. Ask the user to save a small change and reopen the file to ensure persistence.

1. 1. Have the user open the repaired file and make a minor edit (e.g., add a cell comment or type a word).
2. Save the file and close the application.
3. Reopen the file to verify the edit is present and no error messages appear.
4. Ask the user to test another Office document to ensure the application itself is functioning normally.
5. If all checks pass, mark the ticket as resolved and close it.

When to escalate

Escalate to the Application Support team when:

- The file cannot be opened despite Quick Repair, Online Repair, and Open and Repair attempts.
- Multiple users report the same corruption pattern, suggesting a systemic issue (e.g., faulty add-in, problematic Office update, or licensing token problem).
- The user requires data extraction from a severely corrupted Excel workbook where standard repair fails.

Include in the escalation: Office app name and version, exact error messages, file location (local/OneDrive/SharePoint), steps already taken (self-help and agent actions), any relevant screenshots or logs, and the impact (e.g., loss of critical financial model).

Keywords: Excel crash, Word won't open, Office activation prompt, corrupted file, unsaved document, AutoRecover, Safe Mode, Open and Repair, Quick Repair, Online Repair, add-in troubleshooting, license sign-out, version history, file recovery